

The Illusion of Disillusionment

Christopher Lasch, from "The Soul of Man Under Secularism" (1991), 16 numbered paragraphs

For each paragraph this guide gives the argument Lasch is making, why it matters for the essay and for how we think about modernity and religion, and a short synthesis section: what a thoughtful person can take from the paragraph into their own way of seeing the world, whether or not they end up agreeing with Lasch.

Paragraph numbers match the class handout and the quiz site. Quotations are from the handout. The essay was a speech at the Jewish Theological Seminary and answers Freud's *The Future of an Illusion* almost point by point.

The shape of the argument

Lasch is a historian and social critic, and he attacks Freud not by defending doctrines but by exposing the story Freud tells about history. That story says: humanity grew up, lost its childish faith, and now faces reality without illusions. Lasch's title reverses it. The belief that we are uniquely disillusioned is itself the great modern illusion, and it hides the one illusion that really matters, the illusion of mastery.

1. **Paragraphs 1 to 3.** The modern self-image. Freud, Jung, and Weber all picture history as a life cycle from naive childhood faith to adult skepticism. This lets moderns dismiss tradition as regression and cast the intellectual as the brave one who "looks straight into the light."
2. **Paragraphs 4 to 8.** Diagnosis. This self-image is a form of pride. The two modern attitudes to the past, triumphal progress and wistful nostalgia, are secretly the same attitude: both declare the past dead and deny that history still haunts us.
3. **Paragraphs 9 to 12.** The casualty. This habit of mind misreads religion as a source of security and simple answers. In fact religion has always lived with doubt, despair, and the problem of evil: the Carmina Burana, William James, the Book of Job.
4. **Paragraphs 13 to 16.** The reversal. Faith does not fulfil the wish for a father who grants our prayers; it demands that we surrender the wish to control the universe. Modernity's true illusion is mastery through science, and the future of *that* illusion is more doubtful than the future of religion.

Key terms: **disillusionment** (the modern claim to have seen through comforting beliefs), **the life-cycle analogy** (history as growth from childhood to maturity), **nostalgia and progress** (twin forms of modern pride), **the illusion of mastery** (the belief that humanity controls its own destiny), and **dependence** (the human condition that religion, on Lasch's reading, asks us to accept).

The paragraphs

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 1

Modern commentary assumes doubt and despair are new, and pictures history as a person growing from childhood faith to adult skepticism.

"civilization has passed through distinct phases, moving from a childhood of naive faith to the detached skepticism of an adult."

THE ARGUMENT

Lasch surveys the "vast body of commentary on the modern spiritual plight" (Freud, Jung, Weber) and finds one recurring image: the history of culture as the life cycle of an individual. Jung says the medieval world of "children of God" now lies "as far behind as childhood." Freud's "scornful" title implies religion has no future; he calls it a "childhood neurosis" and insists "men cannot remain children for ever."

WHY IT MATTERS

Lasch names the target precisely: not any particular doctrine but a metaphor. Once you see history as growing up, religion automatically becomes something to outgrow. The whole essay is an attempt to make that metaphor visible so it can be questioned. Test tell: the survey of Freud, Jung, and Weber, and the direct quotation of Freud.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

Notice the metaphors you live by. "Growing out of" a belief, "outdated" ideas, being "on the right side of history" all carry the life-cycle picture inside them. The synthesis is not to reject the picture outright but to hold it consciously. Some things really are outgrown (belief in spontaneous generation). Whether faith is one of them cannot be settled by the metaphor; it has to be argued.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 2

The growth metaphor lets moderns dismiss all tradition as clinging to childhood, while envying a faith they cannot return to.

"Once the critical habit of mind has been fully assimilated, no one who understands its implications can find any refuge or resting place in premodern systems of thought and belief."

THE ARGUMENT

The "unexamined premise" that history equals individual growth makes any respect for tradition look like a refusal to mature. Educated people, burdened by sophistication, may envy the naive faith of the past or of the unreflective masses, but they cannot trade places with them any more than they can become children again. Lasch is describing the modern predicament from inside: he understands its appeal.

WHY IT MATTERS

This paragraph shows the emotional shape of modern unbelief: not just intellectual conviction but a kind of exile. It also sets up the later argument that this exile is partly self-inflicted, because the "faith" moderns think they have lost never existed in the naive form they imagine.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

If you have ever envied someone's simple faith while feeling you could never share it, this paragraph names that feeling. Lasch's later move is to question whether the simplicity was ever real. A mature worldview does not require choosing between naive faith and sophisticated unbelief; it can ask whether there is a faith on the far side of criticism, one that has passed through doubt rather than avoided it.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 3

Disillusionment has become the badge of the artist and intellectual, who alone "looks straight into the light without blinking."

"Disillusioned but undaunted: Such is the self-image of modernity, so proud of its intellectual emancipation that it makes no effort to conceal the spiritual price that has to be paid."

THE ARGUMENT

Lasch describes a social hierarchy of enlightenment. Past ages can be forgiven their beliefs; the overworked proletarian can be forgiven; but the "bourgeois philistine" who has access to enlightened culture and still refuses it is contemptible. Only the intellectual faces the truth unflinching. The self-image is heroic, and it even wears its spiritual cost as a decoration.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is a portrait of a class and its vanity. Lasch, a critic of elites throughout his career, is showing that "disillusionment" functions socially as a claim to superiority. The word "pride" has not appeared yet, but this paragraph prepares for it.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

Ask whether your skepticism, or your faith, ever functions as a way of feeling superior to other people. Both can. Lasch's test is uncomfortable but fair: a conviction that mainly serves to distinguish you from the "philistines" is doing social work, not truth-seeking. The synthesis is to keep the courage of looking at hard truths while dropping the self-congratulation.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 4

Playing off our disillusionment against our ancestors' innocence is not harmless; it forces history into two false shapes.

"It betrays a predisposition to read history either as a tragedy of lost illusions or as the progress of critical reason."

THE ARGUMENT

One might dismiss the modern self-image as a "quaint conceit," but Lasch says it springs from an impulse that is "anything but quaint" and has serious consequences. Chief among them: it blocks understanding. It predisposes us to read history in only two ways, as a sad story of lost illusions or a happy story of reason's advance.

WHY IT MATTERS

Short and pivotal. Lasch is moving from description to diagnosis, and he introduces the pair (tragedy of lost illusions / progress of reason) that paragraphs 5 to 8 will show to be one thing in two costumes.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

When you tell the story of your own beliefs, do you tell it as a fall or as an ascent? "I used to believe, then I saw through it" and "I used to be lost, then I found faith" are mirror-image plots. Lasch invites a third possibility: a story in which the past is neither dead nor golden but still present, still asking things of you.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 5

The two versions of the modern myth are not alternatives; they depend on each other.

"It is the progress of critical reason that allegedly leads to lost illusions; disillusionment represents the price of progress."

THE ARGUMENT

Lasch corrects his own "either/or." The tragic story and the triumphant story are "symbiotically dependent." Progress produces disillusionment; disillusionment is what progress costs. They are one narrative, viewed with either a smile or a sigh.

WHY IT MATTERS

The shortest paragraph in the reading, and easy to identify by its brevity and by the "either/or" opener. It is the logical hinge for the nostalgia argument to come.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

The lesson generalizes: when two positions seem to be opposites, check whether they share a premise. Optimists and pessimists about modernity share the premise that modernity broke with the past. Learning to spot shared premises is one of the most useful intellectual habits you can develop, in theology or anywhere else.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 6

Modernity defines itself by the contrast of simplicity and sophistication, and disillusionment is "the characteristic form of modern pride."

"Disillusionment, we might say, is the characteristic form of modern pride."

THE ARGUMENT

The relation of past to present becomes a relation of simple to sophisticated, separated by an "impassable barrier": the experience of disillusionment. Because we have been disillusioned, we can never recapture the innocence of earlier days. And here Lasch names the vice: this posture is pride.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the thesis sentence of the first half. "Pride" is a theological word, the first of the deadly sins, and Lasch is deliberately reframing a secular intellectual attitude as a spiritual fault. The rest of the essay develops the "religious critique of pride" (paragraph 14).

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

Pride here means the refusal to admit that you might be in the same position as your ancestors: dependent, limited, mortal, uncertain. The synthesis is humility about one's own historical moment. We are not the first people to doubt, and we will not be the last to be mistaken. Holding that thought steadily changes how you read old books and how you judge the people who wrote them.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 7

Modern pride shows not only in triumphal progress but also in nostalgia; the two go hand in hand.

"Nostalgia and the idea of progress go hand in hand."

THE ARGUMENT

One expects pride in those who dismiss the past without regret. Lasch's surprising claim is that nostalgia is equally proud. The belief that our civilization has reached "unparalleled complexity" naturally produces a longing for "bygone simplicity." The longing presupposes the superiority.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is a signature Lasch idea, developed at length in his book *The True and Only Heaven*. It explains why he is not a simple conservative: he distrusts sentimental traditionalism as much as progressivism.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

Watch for nostalgia in yourself, whether for a childhood faith, an imagined golden age of the church, or a simpler America. Lasch suggests that nostalgia is a way of keeping the past safely dead: admired, framed, and unable to make demands. The alternative is to treat the past as a living interlocutor that might be right about something you are wrong about.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 8

Nostalgia buries the past alive; both mourners and celebrants deny that history still haunts the present.

"Nostalgia is superficially loving in its re-creation of the past; but it evokes the past only to bury it alive."

THE ARGUMENT

Nostalgia and progressivism share "an eagerness to proclaim the death of the past and to deny history's hold over the present." Both assume our age has "outgrown its childhood." Both find it hard to believe that history "still haunts our enlightened, disillusioned adolescence." Lasch's dry parenthesis (or maturity or senility or whatever stage) mocks the life-cycle metaphor. His final image: both are governed by "the prevailing disbelief in ghosts."

WHY IT MATTERS

The ghost image is the memorable one. Lasch is saying that the past is not gone; the same fears, hopes, and dependencies operate in us as in medieval peasants. Recognizing this

"haunting" is the precondition for understanding religion properly, which is the subject of the next section.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

Take "belief in ghosts" as a metaphor for historical humility: the recognition that older forms of thought are not simply behind us but inside us. A person who believes in ghosts in this sense reads Job, Augustine, or the Psalms as contemporaries rather than as museum pieces. That is a stance you can adopt regardless of your theological conclusions.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 9

The chief casualty of this habit of mind is a misunderstanding of religion as security and simple rules.

"religion is consistently treated as a source of intellectual and emotional security, rather than as a challenge to complacency and pride."

THE ARGUMENT

Modern commentators (Jung again, and the critic Joseph Wood Krutch) picture medieval religion as a "delightfully simple" plan of life, "an exact science" of morals accepted the way scientists accept laws of nature. On this view the only alternative to unquestioning obedience is "moral nihilism": once you doubt, you slide down the slippery slope to relativism and despair.

WHY IT MATTERS

Lasch lays out the caricature carefully before demolishing it, which is why the paragraph is full of quotation. It is the longest in the second half and can be recognized by the names Jung and Krutch and the phrase "exact science." Note that the caricature is shared by religion's critics and by some of its fundamentalist defenders.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

Ask what you think religion is *for*. If the answer is comfort and clear rules, Lasch says you have accepted the modern caricature, whether you are for religion or against it. His alternative, religion as "a challenge to complacency and pride," is a demanding standard. It invites you to judge any faith, including your own, by whether it unsettles you or merely soothes you.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 10

Religion never offered doubt-proof answers; medieval believers knew existential despair. Witness the Carmina Burana.

"they give voice, these disturbing compositions, to an age-old suspicion that the universe is ruled by Fortune, not by Providence."

THE ARGUMENT

Lasch challenges the assumption that religion "ever" provided comprehensive, skepticism-proof answers, or that religious people in the past were strangers to despair. His evidence is the Carmina Burana, songs written by medieval students preparing for the priesthood, which say that life is ruled by Fortune, has no higher purpose, and should be enjoyed while it lasts.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the first piece of historical evidence against the life-cycle story. If future priests in the thirteenth century were singing about a purposeless universe, then doubt is not a modern invention and the "childhood of naive faith" never existed.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

The practical takeaway is that you do not have to choose between faith and honest doubt; historically, believers have held both. If you are religious, this gives you permission to doubt without feeling you have left the tradition. If you are not, it removes the excuse that faith requires switching off your critical mind. Either way, the past becomes a resource rather than an embarrassment.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 11

William James shows that the deepest faith in every age rises out of despair and an awareness of radical evil.

"the deepest variety of religious faith always, in every age, arises out of a background of despair. Religious faith asserts the goodness of being in the face of suffering and evil."

THE ARGUMENT

James's *Varieties of Religious Experience* ignores historical chronology, and Lasch says that indifference is the point: the pattern of conversion is the same in every age. Black despair and bitterness toward a God who permits evil are often the prelude to conversion. Awareness of "radical evil" underlies the surrender that finally brings spiritual peace. And death shadows every pleasure, calling it into question.

WHY IT MATTERS

This paragraph gives Lasch's positive account of what faith is: not the absence of despair but its transformation. It directly answers Freud's paragraph 8. Where Freud sees wish-fulfilment, James and Lasch see "yielding" and "self-surrender," which are the opposite of getting what you wish.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

Lasch's definition, "faith asserts the goodness of being in the face of suffering and evil," is worth memorizing as a test. It excludes cheap optimism (which ignores evil) and excludes despair (which denies goodness). Even someone who does not believe in God can ask whether they affirm the goodness of being, and on what grounds. That question is where the real conversation between believers and unbelievers takes place.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 12

Alienation from God is the normal human condition, not a modern one; the Book of Job already knew that the just suffer.

"Alienation is the normal condition of human existence. Rebellion against God is the natural reaction to the discovery that the world was not made for our personal convenience."

THE ARGUMENT

The modern world has "no monopoly" on the fear of death or alienation from God. Rebellion follows naturally from discovering that the world is not arranged for our convenience, and the discovery that suffering falls on the just and unjust alike is "hard to square" with a benign, omnipotent creator. The Book of Job proves that believers faced this problem long before modernity.

WHY IT MATTERS

Short and quotable. Lasch concedes the strongest argument against religion, the problem of evil, and shows that religion has been arguing with itself about it for millennia. The concession is strategic: it sets up the reversal in paragraph 13.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

Two ideas to carry. First, "the world was not made for our personal convenience" is a truth every worldview must absorb, and rebellion against it is normal, not shameful. Second, the problem of evil is not a modern discovery that ended faith; it is the oldest theme of faith's own literature. If you wrestle with it, you are inside the tradition, not outside it.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 13

Faith requires renouncing the belief that God's purposes match ours. Religion attacks, rather than provides, the wish that our prayers govern the universe.

"the naive belief that our wishes govern the universe is precisely what religion attacks. We have no special claim on the universe, and our prayers are answered only when we surrender that claim."

THE ARGUMENT

The "comfortable belief" that the Almighty's purposes coincide with ours is exactly what faith demands we give up. Religion reminds us of the limits on human power and undermines "the most important superstition of all," that humanity controls its own destiny. Critics (Freud) say religion offers "childlike dependence of a father figure who answers all our prayers." Lasch says the opposite: religion is the attack on that fantasy. Prayers are answered only when the claim to be answered is surrendered. This, he says, is what the prophets have always taught.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the central reversal of the essay and the paragraph to know cold. It takes Freud's thesis (religion equals wish-fulfilment through a father) and inverts it (religion equals renunciation of wish). The phrase "father figure" is the direct nod to Freud.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

Here is where Freud and Lasch can be synthesized rather than merely opposed. Freud is right that a religion which promises to satisfy every wish is an illusion. Lasch is right that the great religious traditions, at their best, teach the surrender of exactly that wish. Both agree that the wish is the enemy. The synthesis: a mature worldview, religious or not, is one that has given up the claim that the universe owes you anything, and then asks what gratitude, trust, or affirmation is still possible. That is a question Freud's essay never reaches.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 14

The religious critique of pride should speak to moderns, but they cannot see the paradox: happiness lies in renouncing the right to be happy.

"the central paradox of religious faith: that the secret of happiness lies in renouncing the right to be happy."

THE ARGUMENT

Modern people find it galling to be reminded of their dependence on powers beyond their control. They cannot reconcile their expectations of success and happiness, "so often undone by events," with a just and loving creator, and they cannot imagine a God who does not treat human happiness as the point of creation. So they miss the paradox at the heart of faith.

WHY IT MATTERS

This paragraph explains why Lasch's argument is hard for his audience to hear, including his religious audience. The paradox is a restatement of an old teaching (whoever loses his life will find it) in the language of rights, which is the language moderns understand. The phrase "renouncing the right to be happy" is the tell.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

You can test the paradox against experience without any theology. Do people who insist on their right to happiness tend to be happy? Does the pursuit of happiness as a possession work? Much of the wisdom literature of every culture, and a good deal of modern psychology, says no. If the paradox holds, it is a piece of your worldview that religion has been guarding, and it belongs to you whether or not you accept the God who was said to guard it.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 15

What is modern is not lost dependence but a more pervasive rebellion against it, seemingly licensed by science.

"What makes the modern temper modern, then, is not that we have lost our childish sense of dependence but that the normal rebellion against dependence is more pervasive today than it used to be."

THE ARGUMENT

Lasch's answer to the essay's implicit question. Freud said we lost the child's dependence. Lasch says we never lost it; what changed is that the normal human rebellion against dependence has spread. Flannery O'Connor is cited to show that finding the truth of faith "hideous" and "repulsive" for long periods is an ordinary experience of believers. If the

whole world now seems to be in "a dark night of the soul," it is because science appears to sanction the rebellion, the same science that supposedly destroyed superstition.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the diagnostic conclusion. Modernity is not maturity but adolescence: a stage of rebellion against dependence, mistaking itself for independence. The O'Connor quotation and "dark night of the soul" mark the paragraph.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

The distinction between *losing* dependence and *rebellling against* it is the one to keep. Whatever you believe about God, you depend on things you do not control: your body, other people, the climate, luck. A worldview that pretends otherwise is adolescent in Lasch's sense. The mature question is not how to escape dependence but how to live in it without either resentment or servility.

LASCH, PARAGRAPH 16

The one illusion that survives is the illusion of mastery, and its future is more in doubt than religion's.

"In an age that fancies itself as disillusioned, this is the one illusion -- the illusion of mastery -- that remains as tenacious as ever."

THE ARGUMENT

Science's machines let us imagine ourselves masters of our fate. That is the illusion modernity has not shed. But as we learn the limits of our control over nature, "the future of this illusion," in Freud's own phrase, looks shakier than the future of religion. Lasch ends by turning Freud's title against Freud.

WHY IT MATTERS

The conclusion completes the reversal announced in the essay's title. Freud predicted religion would fade as the illusion of a protecting father dissolved. Lasch replies that the father was swapped for the machine, and the machine is the illusion whose future is really in doubt. Written in 1991, with environmental limits in view, the paragraph has aged well.

SYNTHESIS FOR YOUR OWN WORLDVIEW

Lasch's essay ends where an honest worldview should begin: with the admission that we are not in control. From there, the paths divide. One can respond with despair, with stoic acceptance, or with the trust that Lasch, following James and the prophets, calls faith. But all three begin from the same renunciation. Whatever you conclude, the synthesis of Freud and Lasch is this: identify your illusions, including the flattering modern one that you have none, and then decide, with your eyes open, what you will affirm about the goodness of being.

Pulling it together: what to keep from Lasch

- **Suspicion of the "growing up" story.** History is not an individual's biography. Doubt, despair, and the problem of evil are permanent features of human life, not modern discoveries.
- **The unity of nostalgia and progress.** Both bury the past. Learning to spot this makes you a better reader of politics, religion, and your own memories.
- **Religion as challenge, not comfort.** Lasch's definition, faith as the affirmation of the goodness of being in the face of evil, is a standard by which to judge any religion, including one's own.
- **The reversal of Freud.** Faith does not fulfil the wish for a father who grants prayers; it renounces the wish to be the center of the universe. The illusion of mastery is the one that really needs examining.
- **Places to push back.** Lasch describes religion at its best and Freud's target at its worst; a great deal of actual religion *is* comfort-seeking and rule-bound. His argument that faith requires surrender does not by itself show that there is anything to surrender to. And his use of "pride" quietly imports the theology he is defending.

The most productive way to hold the two readings together: Freud teaches you to distrust what you wish for; Lasch teaches you that the deepest religious traditions have always taught the same distrust, and then asked a further question about what remains once the wish is gone. Your own worldview is what you answer.